

Sports **BASEBALL**



Patel holding open the door, a newly-learned courtesy. On the study table are a bunch of CDs and a slightly worn-out copy of *Baseball for Dummies*. It's the only English book they have tried to read. Singh, the taller of the two at 6'2" settles in front of their laptop. Patel, stockier, sits on one of the beds and relives their journey.

The more he speaks, the more this seems like a wacky social experiment. Airlift two boys from Indian villages and drop them into a country where they can't understand the language. Give them brand new gadgets, and make them play an alien sport.

Initially based in the University of Southern California, they addressed their first press conference through an interpreter. "There was one thing they were asked over and over again," says J.B. Bernstein, the creator of *The Million Dollar Arm*, a marketing initiative from Bernstein's sports management firm. "Did they see parallels between their story and *Slumdog Millionaire*? Every time they just smiled patiently and tried to explain the difference between farming villages and slums." They still laugh about it. "We kept explaining that we didn't live near a garbage dump. Initially we felt bad but now we just

joke about it", Patel says.

Singh is busy on Facebook. This is a boy who hadn't seen a laptop till a day before boarding the flight to the US. In the early days, apart from baseball, they learnt about Google, Youtube, chat, voice chat and social networking. Patel now starts his day by reading *Dainik Jagran* online. "It feels as if I'm at home." Rarely have the Indians been made to feel otherwise, especially in a squad made up of players from 11 countries and five continents. Of the 35 players, there are nine each from the Dominican Republic and Venezuela, six from the US, two from Puerto Rico and India and one from Mexico, Panama, Australia, Canada, South Africa and Lithuania.

Spanish is the dominant language in the team but pitching coach Miguel Bonillo doesn't think that is an imped-



iment. "I think we're lucky to have so many different perspectives," says the Dominican coach. "And everyone in the team understands the language of baseball. That's enough."

On an online conversation with a teammate, Singh throws up words like "opportunity", "disappointed" and "rhythm". Where has this vocabulary come from? "We grew up learning the great language of Sanskrit," says Patel. "Picking up English has been so much easier."

The biggest challenge has been neither culture nor dislocation but "learning baseball," says Singh. For most Americans, the sport is a centrepiece of family life, handed down from one generation to the next, with all its history and nuances.

And nuances there are aplenty. The pitcher has to watch the catcher (equivalent of the wicket-keeper), who in turn watches the coach in the dug-out. The coach usually signals by pointing to some part of his face, the catcher then communicates this to the pitcher with hand gestures. It gives a pitcher barely a couple of seconds to process the instruction, get into his stance and pitch accurately. Or he might have to abandon his pitch and instead try to run another batter out.

**THEY HAVE MADE
UP 20 YEARS OF
LOST GROUND.
NOW THEY HAVE TO
COMPETE TO MOVE
UP TO THE MAJORS.**